

Toddler Sleep Battles — Action Checklist

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TRACK YOUR CHILD'S PATTERN

- ☐ **Track Your Child's Pattern:** Keep a sleep log for three nights, recording what happens in the hour before bed and what specific resistance behaviors occur during bedtime, to identify whether your child is experiencing separation anxiety, fear-based resistance, autonomy-seeking stalling, or control-seeking negotiation.
- ☐ **Track Your Child's Pattern:** Notice if your child panics when you leave the room but settles when you return—this pattern indicates separation anxiety rather than defiance, and means your child needs help managing genuine fear, not just discipline.
- ☐ **Track Your Child's Pattern:** Identify if resistance shows up as stalling requests or boundary-testing at predictable moments—this signals autonomy-seeking behavior driven by your toddler's need to practice their new sense of agency and power.
- ☐ **Track Your Child's Pattern:** Watch for fear-based resistance like statements of being scared, refusal to close eyes, or worry about shadows or sounds—these indicate imagination-driven fears that feel completely real to your child.

RECOGNIZE DEVELOPMENTAL CAUSES

- ☐ **Recognize Developmental Causes:** Understand that separation anxiety at this age is caused by your child's evolved object permanence, meaning they now know you exist separately from them and can potentially not come back, which feels genuinely threatening.
 - ☐ **Recognize Developmental Causes:** Accept that imagination-driven fears are a sign of normal cognitive development, not irrational behavior—your child is not weak or manipulative, they simply lacks the words to express legitimate fears about what they imagine in the dark.
 - ☐ **Recognize Developmental Causes:** Accept that bedtime resistance is not a parenting failure—your toddler's brain is wired to resist sleep at this developmental stage, and the standard sleep advice was never designed for what's actually happening in their developing mind.
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- **Recognize Developmental Causes:** Understand that your toddler is not being manipulative when they negotiate or stall—they are testing boundaries and learning where their power lies, which is a critical developmental task at this age.

SHIFT YOUR RESPONSE APPROACH

- **Shift Your Response Approach:** Build a consistent wind-down architecture that signals sleep time through the same sequence of activities every night, creating a reliable pattern that your toddler's developing brain can recognize as a cue to prepare for rest.
- **Shift Your Response Approach:** Respond to bedtime resistance with empathy instead of control, recognizing that your child is expressing genuine anxiety or testing boundaries rather than trying to manipulate you into staying up later.
- **Shift Your Response Approach:** Create a wind-down period that avoids stimulating activities in the final hour before bed, because roughhousing, screen time, or emotionally charged interactions can escalate resistance and make sleep feel like an unwelcome transition.
- **Shift Your Response Approach:** Address fear-based resistance directly by acknowledging what your child is afraid of and providing comfort, rather than dismissing the fear as unreasonable or forcing them to sleep when they're experiencing real terror.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.